Gosoor Marketplace: How the Old Website Worked

A plain-language summary of the old WordPress site (gosoor.com.eg/marketplace), written for business readers. It has been offline since September 2022.

1. What the site was for

Gosoor was an online marketplace connecting Egyptian manufacturers ("suppliers") with buyers, mostly companies importing goods from Egypt. Suppliers listed their products, and buyers asked for price quotes instead of buying straight away.

How Gosoor made money:

- **A service fee charged to buyers** on each deal, between 3% and 6%. Buyers who ordered more each month paid a lower percentage. Suppliers paid nothing per sale.
- **Paid supplier memberships** (optional subscription plans).

2. Who used it

Group	How many	What they did
Suppliers	1,181	Ran their own online shop and listed products
Buyers	about 23	Browsed and requested quotes
Gosoor staff	about 60	Admins, shop managers, operations and logistics, management
Service providers	about 20	Companies offering services such as logistics

3. Signing up

- **Buyers** gave their name, company, address, phone and tax number, and were linked to a Gosoor sales branch and a salesperson.
- **Suppliers** also gave their commercial registration number and export card number. Gosoor approved each supplier before their shop went live.

4. Products

- About **16,500 products** with **26,000 photos**.
- **97 categories**, organised the way customs authorities classify goods (furniture, plastics, carpets, aluminium, electrical goods, clothing, medical items and so on).
- Each product could carry:
  - A minimum order quantity.

    - A selling unit (piece, ton, square metre and so on).
    - Colour and size options.
    - Its cost.
- **New products** from suppliers waited for Gosoor's approval before going live.

5. The shopping experience

- Buyers could browse categories, search, visit each supplier's shop, save favourites to a wishlist, and compare products side by side.
- Prices were shown in US dollars, with an option to view other currencies.
- **There was no "Add to cart" button.** Buyers could only add products to a **quote request list** and send it to Gosoor.

6. How a deal happened

1. The buyer sends a quote request.
2. Gosoor passes it to the supplier.
3. The supplier accepts or rejects it.
4. If accepted, the buyer gets an order to pay. If nobody acts within 7 days, the request expires.
5. A Gosoor staff member manually adds the service fee to the order.
6. The buyer pays by **bank transfer**, the only payment option available.
7. The order moves through "Processing" to "Completed".

7. What suppliers could do

- See sales statistics, including sales by country.
- Add and edit products.
- Handle their orders and accept or reject quotes.
- Message buyers and Gosoor, and open support tickets.
- Read a help library and announcements from Gosoor.
- See their balance and request weekly payouts by bank transfer.

8. What Gosoor staff could do

- Approve suppliers and products.
- Set the buyer service-fee levels.
- Calculate the fee on each order with one button.
- Print PDF invoices.

- Manage the sales team: 7 branches, branch managers, account managers and independent sales agents ("brokers"). Each customer was assigned to a branch and either an account manager or a broker.
- See which orders had been sent to the company's accounting system.

9. Connected systems

- **Accounting system (Odoo and Microsoft Dynamics 365):** received customers, products, suppliers and quotes.
- **Email:** sent and tracked about 3,900 emails.
- **Mailchimp:** email marketing.
- **Google:** site statistics and search listing.
- **Backup and security tools.**

10. Where it ended up (September 2022)

	Number
Suppliers	1,181
Live products	16,500
Buyers	9
Completed orders	0 (2 quotes expired)
Messages exchanged	about 2,500

In short: Gosoor attracted suppliers but not buyers.

11. Lessons for iCommerce

1. **Let people buy directly.** Quote-only buying slowed everything down. Keep quotes for large company orders and add a normal cart and checkout.
2. **Offer more ways to pay.** Bank transfer alone isn't enough; add cash on delivery and cards.
3. **Automate fees and quotes.** Manual steps by staff caused delays and errors. The old fee calculation sometimes picked the wrong level.
4. **Keep it simple.** The old site relied on about 55 add-ons, which made it slow and fragile.
5. **Speak the customer's language.** The site was almost entirely in English; iCommerce will be fully English and Arabic.
6. **Build demand, not just supply.** Marketing to buyers matters as much as signing up suppliers.